# Night Escapades on Cross Street

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# Bird Companion

CH23601-01

Months from now, flyers for the Uluru Games will be drifting on the wind, bringing long-awaited good news to this city shrouded in thick fog.

But, the locals know nothing of it yet, including Liberti Grove. In East London, she finishes her knocker-upper work for the morning and makes her way home ... once more, on her own.

Before she makes a stop beneath a fateful eave.

Liberti: *chirps*

Bird: Chirp?

Liberti: *chirps*?

Bird: Chirp, chirp?

Their cross-species interaction takes place on the corner, its participants oblivious to any onlookers, yet inevitably catching their eyes.

Classmate I: Oi, look who it is? It's Little Miss Why!

Classmate II: Hm? Is she trying to talk with that bird? Not surprised, two odd birds together.

Classmate I: You ain't half-wrong!

The children burst into laughter, roughhousing as they leave. Liberti looks back to the little blue bird on the eaves once again.

Liberti: Don't pay them no mind. They're just like that.

Liberti: Could be they're onto somethin', though. My bird-talk's a bit rusty, and you don't speak English neither, do ya?

Liberti: Clocked you hangin' about a while ago. Been followin' me, have you? You fancy us being mates?

Bird: Chirp?

Liberti: If you're tryin' to say "yes," then let's get a move on, eh?

Liberti's Home

Liberti: Shh. Keep it down. Mum don't care for being disturbed while she's workin'. She'll go on a proper rampage.

Liberti: Just like this. Try to slip in through the window. Right.

Bird: Chirp.

Liberti: Blimey, you actually came! So, I was right. You do wanna be mates.

Liberti: Fancy some bread? It's all I've got for supper. Let's share it. Here, I'll break off some bits for ya.

The bird hops forward, peering over the bread with its beady black eyes before turning away.

Liberti: Why? What's wrong? Don't care for bread?

Liberti: Oh! A bit dry, innit? Hang on. I'll fetch ya some water.

Liberti turns to find her father leaning on the doorframe, rubbing his forehead, a tired look on his face.

Father: Liberti, you're back.

Liberti: You up, Dad? Why you rubbin' your head? Still got a sore noggin'?

Her father came home late last night, knocking on the door in a drunken haze, and now looks as though he has only just rolled out of bed. Every night before his day off, he drinks with his coworkers "until the last drop's been drunk."

Liberti has never been fond of the sharp scent of alcohol clinging to her father, but she knows he isn't fond of it himself.

Her father says nothing in response.

Father: Who you talkin' to?

Liberti: My new mate. See?

Liberti moves aside, introducing her father to the tiny guest standing on the windowsill.

Father: *sigh* You don't mean the bird, do ya? What am I to do with you, girl?

Father: Why can't you be more like the other little'uns on the street, y'know, behave a bit more proper?

Father: They don't go off talkin' to birds all day. They go out and play with each other instead.

Liberti: But I don't like playin' with them.

Father: "Unsociable," that's what your teachers call you. Now, I've warned you already. You can't go on acting like this and do strange things.

Liberti: What do you mean "strange things"?

Father: *sigh* You always gotta mouth back to me, eh?

Liberti: I still don't get it. I weren't mouthin' off, Dad. I just don't see why—

The door inside is flung wide open, hitting the wall with a loud thud.

Mother: Shush! Must you two make such an awful racket?

The true head of the Grove household stands in the doorway, exuding a silent, threatening aura. The pair go quiet at once.

Father: ...

Liberti: Sorry, Mum.

Mother: You know that while you're off having fun at school, I'm working myself to the bone, don't ya?

Mother: From the second I open my eyes, it's naught but sewin' and weavin' for me! All day long! I'm gonna make myself blind from all this work!

Mother: So all I want's a bit of peace! Is that too much to ask?

Father and daughter bow their heads, silently saying a quiet prayer that this storm might pass over them.

However, the storm has other ideas. Mother's gaze suddenly hardens, fixing in place.

Liberti watches in confusion as she steps closer, inch by inch, until she finally stops at the windowsill, staring in disbelief at the half-eaten bread and the little bird perched nearby.

Mother: What were you thinking, Liberti? Feeding your bread ... to a bleedin' bird?

Liberti: I ... I ... It's only a bit of my supper, and I don't mind sharin'! It's just that she's my new mate, and I just thought I'd give her somethin'—

Mother: Oh, don't mind sharing, do we?

Mother: Miss Liberti Grove, our own little Lady Bountiful, givin' out our bread to the poor little bird!

Mother: We don't work as hard as we do for you to feed your bird!

Bird: Chirp, chirp!

Liberti's new friend flits away from the window—a little disloyal, perhaps, but Liberti knows she can't be blamed.

Father: Ease up. I'm sure Liberti knows she did wrong. And she won't be doing it again, will she?

Father: Liberti, how about you go and fetch next week's shopping? Lend a hand around here, eh?

Father: Go get some money from your sister. I wrote the shoppin' list in a blank spot on the newspaper. Right here. Go on, off you trot!

The shopping list is shoved into Liberti's hand, and she is pushed out the door.

Unfortunately for her, council house doors are not known for their soundproofing.

Mother: That girl can't keep carryin' on like this. You've got to talk some sense into her.

Father: I've told her time and again, but does she ever listen?

Liberti: ...

Bird: Chirp.

The lilting sound of a bird reaches her ears from above. Liberti looks up, her smile returning once more.

Liberti: Waitin' for me, were you? Thanks. I was in need of some cheerin' up after all that.

Liberti: Sorry. I hope they didn't give you too much of a fright. They ain't always so cross.

Liberti: I'm off to find Sarah, my sister. She's usually down here with her union lot. You could wait with me if you like.

Bird: Chirp.

Satisfied by the bird's answer, Liberti heads up the stairs. Just as she's about to knock, a large, broad-shouldered worker stops her.

Worker: Hey! What d'you think yer doin'? This ain't no playground, girly!

The worker eyes Liberti suspiciously, to him she's just another little mischief maker sneaking around and stirring up trouble. That is, until he hears the name of another "grown-up."

Liberti: I'm here for Sarah.

Worker: Right! I remember you, the little sister, ain't ya? 'Ang on then. I'll fetch her.

He motions toward Liberti, wordlessly impressing that she should stay by the entrance.

Liberti: I don't like it much in there. Everyone's got faces redder than slapped backsides.

Bird: Chirp, chirp?

Waiting at the door, she and the bird resume their friendly chatter.

Liberti: I think Sarah's proper clever, and I do look up to her. Only ... sometimes I think she don't much care for me.

Liberti: Mum and Dad were saying that Sarah's running for union leader. And if she wins, then she might move away.

Liberti: If she leaves, then I won't get to see much of her anymore. I don't know if that'd make me feel chuffed or gutted. Just thinkin' about it makes me feel a bit funny inside.

Bird: Chirp, chirp!

The little bird perched above tilts its head and flutters down, landing softly on Liberti's drooping shoulder.

Liberti: Oi! What are you like?! That tickles, haha!

Liberti: By the way, sorry about the bread. I hoped you'd get a bit more than you did. And I was plannin' to introduce you to Ollie. S'pose it'll have to wait till next time.

Liberti and her avian companion wait at the stoop of the doorway for a long while, and a touch of boredom begins to set in.

Liberti: Oh, I know! How about I show you a bit o' magic? You up for that?

She reaches into her pocket for the half-sheet of newspaper, flattens it carefully, and pinches a corner, making the entire sheet stand upright.

Liberti: Watch close now.

Sarah: Stop! What are you doing?

A hardened hand, thick with calluses, seizes Liberti's wrist, sending the shopping list tumbling to the ground.

Sarah: You really doing "that" again? How many times have we—ugh, again and again—don't do "that"!

Liberti: I-I ... was only ...

Sarah: You haven't been doing that little trick of yours around town, have you? Trying to get some attention? Showing off to your schoolmates? Your friends?

Liberti: I haven't!

Sarah: You'd better not have.

Sarah fixes Liberti with a hard look, then finally lets go of her reddened wrist.

Sarah: Remember this now. Don't go causing trouble for our family.

Liberti: That ain't true. I ain't causing no trouble! I'm doing my part as a knocker-up, aren't I?

Sarah: Oh aye, very impressive. And you know what I was doing at your age? Working four jobs in all.

Sarah: That was after the war! Before then—well, you don't know nothing about how rough it was then. I was younger than you are now, but I still made sure I was always seen and not heard. You've no idea how hard we had to work to get us here.

Liberti's head drops once again.

Bird: Chirp, chirp.

The bird nudges her cheek with its wing, and once more, Liberti lifts her head.

Liberti: Why do you always do that? Why you always goin' on about how things used to be?

Liberti: And why do you always tell me not to use "that"?

Sarah: You wouldn't understand even if I explained. Just remember what I've told you. You'll appreciate it when you're older.

Liberti: I don't get it. It's always "when you're older," but why that the way it has to be? If you've got all the answers, why don't ya just tell me now?

Sarah: How is it you come up with so many questions? There's no why!

A few passersby begin to glance their way. Sarah clears her throat and speaks more quietly.

Sarah: Enough. I've no time for your usual nonsense. Just tell me what you're up to.

Liberti: ...

Without a word, Liberti reaches into her pocket and hands over the shopping list with a bended head.

Sarah: The shopping, is it? Well, it does need doing ... *sigh*

Her sister frowns as she digs into her pocket and counts out the coins one by one.

Sarah: Here, this should do. And if the shopkeeper says it's short, you tell him he can forget about trying to charge us more!

Sarah: And if there's any change, you bring it right back. No sweets, understand?

After giving her strict instructions, Sarah heads back inside, pulling the heavy door shut behind her.

Liberti: I won't use it for sweets, honest.

Still, she plans to go to Mr. Laury's shop later, because she has to go home after the shopping's done.

For the time being, she has no desire to head home.

# Stolen Name

CH23601-02

Bird: Chirp.

Liberti makes her way down to the lake, her little bird friend fluttering along beside her.

Liberti: Still tryin' to cheer me up, eh?

Liberti: But I'm alright, really. Just give us a moment. I'll be right as rain in a tick.

Every child has their own secret hideaway, and whenever Liberti feels the urge to slip away, she finds her way here.

Many legends surround this spot. The grown-ups warn of the dreadful Jenny Greenteeth, who drags careless children into the lake to meet a watery end.

They also say mischievous fairies roam the area, stealing prized possessions from unwary children. They also say ...

As she thinks about it, Liberti realizes she's never actually encountered any of these creatures. Maybe they're nothing more than scary stories dreamt up by adults to keep their kids from straying too far away.

In which case, this quiet little haven really is all hers—a place no other children would try to claim, where Liberti can spend her time in peace before heading home for supper.

Liberti sits by the lake, pulling out the shopping list her father gave her, then ...

Liberti: Look. A little fold here, and it's done!

Liberti: Look at that, a little bird just like you! Like lookin' in a mirror, it is!

Bird: Chirp, chirp!

Liberti: I want to be like you, then I could fly, fly off somewhere else.

Liberti: Might be somewhere else. There's an exciting adventure waitin' for me, far away from all these worries.

Liberti: Could you take me there?

Bird: Chirp, chirp?

Liberti: Fair enough, s'pose that's askin' a bit much from a little thing like you. I was only teasin'.

Liberti: Remember me sayin' I wanted to introduce you to Ollie? He's a bird too. Just happens to be a rooster, that's all.

Liberti: See, people ain't too keen on Ollie's crowin' and wakin' 'em up in the morning, so I keep with him down in the cellar.

Liberti: Ollie always wakes me up bright and early, and then I go ahead and wake everyone else up, tappin' on folk's windows with a pole, right when I'm supposed to ...

As she reaches this point, Liberti's voice falters. Her hands slacken, and the little paper bird sags in her grip, feeling weight again as her energy wanes.

Liberti: But let me tell you a little secret.

Liberti: If I'm being straight, I don't really need Ollie to wake me up. Kippin' with him in the cellar just makes me feel more like home, y'know?

Liberti: Mum, Dad, and even Sarah. I know they love me, and I love 'em too. But sometimes, they're just, well, they're like what you saw.

Liberti: I don't get it. Why we can't all have a good laugh together now and then? We might not have much, but we could still be happy with what we got, couldn't we?

Liberti: What d'you reckon? Eh?

Silence settles around her. Liberti's new friend has vanished without a trace.

Liberti: Oh, well, cheerio for now. Coulda said a proper goodbye first. Wouldn't have killed ya.

Liberti: So, back on my lonesome again.

Liberti stretches out her arms and legs, sinking into the soft grass.

Feeling the breeze drift across her cheek, she imagines herself as a paper page, ready to be carried off by the flutter of the wind.

Liberti: Hang about. What's that?!

High among the tree branches above her, there is something lurking, hidden in the leaves.

Liberti: Yah. Oof!

A gust of wind lifts her skirt, and Liberti lets go of the branch, landing softly on the ground.

Liberti: You were tucked right outta sight up there. Good thing I don't mind climbin' trees! Let's have a butcher's ... What've we got 'ere?

Liberti: A pouch? Someone must've left it up there. It says ...

Liberti: ...

Liberti: Oh! I gotta say, this is proper clever.

Liberti: 'Cause I figure if it just said "Open Me," well, then I'd never open it. That'd be too obvious.

Liberti: If it said "Don't Open Me," I'd still think twice. It's a bit on the nose, innit?

Liberti: But this ...

Liberti: "Don't! Open Me" ...

Liberti: Nicely done. I'll bite.

???: Hello! Are you alright?

???: Why are you sleeping here? Wake up!

Liberti: Mmm, mornin'. That was a lovely nap.

Liberti: Oooh! Hold on, when did I nod off? Is it nighttime already?

Still drowsy, Liberti wakes herself up, springing up from the soft grass and glancing around in a daze at the girl standing beside her.

Girl: I do apologize. I hope I'm not interrupting. But, this isn't the safest spot for a nap, you know? Hasn't anybody ever warned you?

Girl: People say crafty fairies wander about out here, waiting to swipe your most precious possessions when you aren't watching.

Liberti: It's you.

The girl is one of the few children she's seen out in these woods. They've waved in passing before, yet never even told each other their names.

Liberti: I didn't think anyone who comes out here would believe all that.

Girl: But they're all real! Bluecaps, Jack Frost, the Girt Dog, Pistosaurs, Black Annis ... every one of them.

Girl: Though most of them aren't nearly as nasty as they say, you do get the odd troublemaker. You might wanna have a look if you're missing something.

Liberti: Let's have a look then, purse, shopping list ... yep, all here. I've not lost nothing.

Girl: Isn't this yours?

The girl pulls a very familiar pouch from her pocket. Its label dispels any lingering doubt.

Liberti: That? No, I found it up in a tree.

Liberti: Hang on, I remember now! It was right as I opened that pouch that I got all drowsy.

Girl: Erm, but doesn't it say "Don't! Open Me" on it?

Liberti: Yes! And who could resist openin' a bag that says "Don't! Open Me"? Come on now!

Girl: I suppose you have got a point.

The girl hands over the pouch. Liberti takes it.

Girl: But this is so ... curious.

Girl: It's the perfect sort of trap a pesky fairy would leave. Are you absolutely sure nothing's missing?

Liberti: I ... don't think so.

Girl: Well, alright then, if you say so.

Girl: Don't you think you ought to get back? You're always home before sunset, but it's well past that now.

Liberti: You're right. I've still gotta do the weekly shop, and I'm in for a proper earful tonight. But, wait, how'd you know that?

The girl clears her throat, looking somewhat bashful.

Girl: I always sneak a peek at you when you come around here, 'cause you can do "that" too, can't you?

Liberti: "That"? You mean ...

It takes only a second for Liberti to comprehend what the girl is talking about.

Sarah's scolding echoes in Liberti's mind, yet the strange girl looks at her with such expectant eyes.

Liberti: Wanna see?

Girl: Really?

The echoes are gone the next second.

Liberti: Of course!

Liberti: This oughta do.

Though her little blue bird friend is nowhere to be seen, the paper bird Liberti made remains close at hand.

She lifts it gently from the grass, resting it in the center of her open palm.

Liberti: Watch carefully.

Liberti: Hah!

Liberti throws the paper bird into the air.

At that moment, the wind rises.

A gust ruffles Liberti's dress and dances lightly through the girls' soft hair.

The little bird flies upward.

Girl: Wow! You called up the wind, just like that!

Liberti: Yes, but it only works on paper or cloth, an' only with light stuff. I can't budge nothin' heavy.

Girl: So, you're saying you never lifted yourself up and tried to fly?

Liberti: That's the long and short of it. I can't fly. Least, not yet.

Girl: That's a shame.

Girl: Still, though, what you can do is impressive all the same! Just think—there's probably no one who can throw a paper plane further than you!

Liberti blinks a few times as she mulls over the notion.

Liberti: Got a point there. Never thought of it like that. We'll have to try it next time!

Liberti: But promise me you'll keep mum about this, alright? My sis don't want me doin' "this" in front of people.

Girl: Of course. I'll keep quiet. But what's the fuss, anyway? We were just flying a paper bird.

Liberti: I reckon it's 'cause she's worried I'll end up in trouble.

Liberti: I don't get it, to be honest.

Liberti: "There's no why," Sarah said. Maybe she's right.

Liberti: Since there's no answer, there ain't no point stressin' it. The grown-ups sussed that out ages ago, so that's why they don't bother askin'.

Liberti: Maybe it's time I grew up a bit, stopped thinkin' so much 'bout all these silly little things. Be sensible, eh?

Liberti gazes out over the calm lake in the distance, letting silence briefly rule this small, secret place.

Liberti: But I still don't get it.

Liberti: Why's it "There's no why"?

As Liberti's question hangs in the air, a fleeting moment follows, the only sound a gentle whisper of the breeze over the lake.

The girl opposite Liberti blinks as at last a smile spreads across her face.

Girl: "Why's it there's no why"? A bit of a tongue-twister that is. Still ...

Girl: I might just know someone who could answer that question.

Liberti: What? Really?!

Girl: Of course. I know someone. Everyone calls her the Administrator, and she knows the answer to everything. Maybe we could ask her someday.

Liberti: The answer to everything?

Liberti: Sounds a bit dodgy. How does she pull that off? Do you reckon she knows what I had for supper last night?

Girl: Of course, she does! One time, she even told me the fifth letter on the third line of page twenty in my favorite book!

From fairies snatching away belongings to a mysterious woman with all the answers, Liberti's new friend seems to live in a world full of fantastical marvels.

Liberti: Well, I have to say I'm intrigued. What do ya say we meet up here tomorrow after school?

Girl: You're on. I'll be here right on time.

It doesn't take long for the two of them to agree on their next adventure.

Lamplighter: They call me Lamplighter. What should I call you?

Liberti: Me name's !+*?%&#.

She begins to speak, yet the words stall in her lips. The sounds, poised to come to life, simply fade away.

Lib?%&#: The name is ... !+* ...

!+*?%&#: Wait.

!+*?%&#: What is my name?

Lamplighter: Oh, no! This isn't good news!

Lamplighter: Now we know what those pesky fairies stole after all! They stole your name!

# Cross Street

CH23601-03

!+*?%&#: Pardon?

!+*?%&#: You mean those fairies nicked me own ... name?

Under normal circumstances, she'd say the whole situation was entirely daft. Yet such concerns are far from her mind in this moment.

Lamplighter: That's right! And now that night's falling, "it" is on its way!

No sooner does she finish speaking than the dark woods in the distance start to seethe and shift.

There is something in the darkness. A sense of dread fills the girl who has lost her name.

!+*?%&#: Wh-What's that?!

Lamplighter: It's the Bananach!

Lamplighter: It's a murderous beast! One which unfortunately goes after anyone who doesn't have a name!

!+*?%&#: Ehhh?!

Darkness begins to engulf their surroundings, the moon's light disappears completely, surrendering the world to a black abyss.

The scene unfolds too suddenly, denying the girl a moment to voice her disbelief.

Lamplighter: It's coming right for us! We need to get out of here, now!

Lamplighter grabs the girl's arm and pulls her along, as the hollow, terrifying roars of the darkness echo close behind.

!+*?%&#: Huff ... puff ... Good thing ... I still remember ... how to run ...!

Lamplighter: Almost there. Through that cave, and we'll be back to the streets!

!+*?%&#: C-Cave?

She can't recall ever seeing a cave like this around here.

But there's no time for her to think about that now. She follows Lamplighter headlong into the pitch-black passage.

Unsurprisingly, the cave is dark, so dark that she cannot see her hand in front of her face.

!+*?%&#: ...!

She treads carefully through the lightless passage.

The inky blackness wraps around her like a viscous liquid, until she's unable to make out even where the ground is, no matter how hard she stares.

The creature of darkness, Bananach. The name Lamplighter called out in distress now echoes in her mind.

!+*?%&#: Ah! Lamplighter! It's pitch black in here. I can't see me own hands!

The girl instinctively calls in the direction of her friend's fading steps.

Lamplighter: Oh, my mistake. Just a moment.

A single, clear knock resounds, and the darkness is swept away.

!+*?%&#: Wow! You've got a lamp! I'd completely forgotten about that thing!

Lamplighter: That's why they call me Lamplighter. This little light of mine helps me guide people along.

Lamplighter: But this teensy bit of light won't scare the Bananach. Let's make a run for the street. Come on!

Lamplighter takes her hand, and the two girls break into a dash once more.

This time, a soft glow illuminates the ground ahead, allowing them to run without fear of falling.

The girls keep running and running on for what feels like an eternity, until at last, the darkness seems to have shrunk far behind them.

The path ahead clears, and an incredible street filled with illuminated wonders stretches out before them.

Friendly Merchant: New wares just in! Step right up! Corn dollies, strong as they come, for harvestin' yer spuds and keepin' the undead at bay!

Yelling Coal: 50 Sharpodonties for a ride.

Peddling Soul: Oof. Who's in the market for a bit o' sorrow? Freshly bottled wails. Any kind ya like and made to measure!

Busy Mother: Keep up, girls! You'll be late for class! Oi, put that down! If you think we're buying that, you can think again!

Plant Newsboy: Extra! Extra! Read all about it! Notorious playground bully, Scone, the scoundrel known to harass little Bugbears for their pocket money, finally nabbed by the Girt Dog of Ennerdale ...

The street teems with life, and the stalls overflow with curios she's never seen before, as strange creatures of all shapes and sizes hurry past.

A critter calls out to would-be customers, beyond him, a chatty lump of coal, a timid ghost, a trundling family of beasts, and a strange plant selling newspapers on the corner ...

Little lights chase each other round and round along the rooftops, and back down again to a bear swigging a drink from a honey jar, as a scarecrow knits while watching over its vegetable stall, and ... and ...

Her mouth falls agape and refuses to close.

!+*?%&#: Where am I?

Lamplighter: This is Criss-Cross Street. Haven't you never been here before?

Criss-Cross Street

!+*?%&#: Me mum says Cross Street's where all the arcanists hang around. She don't want me mixin' with 'em, so she keeps me well away from here.

!+*?%&#: Wow! But I've ain't never heard of all these sorts livin' on Cross Street. You sure we're on the right road?

Lamplighter: Of course, we are! Critters have called this place home since before anyone can remember.

Lamplighter: Only thing is, it looks different to each person who enters it. Most folks can't manage to find their way into "this" Cross Street.

Lamplighter: And it's even harder if there's no one to guide you. Follow me!

Lamplighter leads the now nameless girl down the marvelous street ahead of them, accepting all sorts of peculiar treats from the magical vendors and stuffing them into her friend's hands.

The critters offer kind greetings to Lamplighter and to the nameless girl. Her mouth full of treats as she waves back with a stuffed smile.

!+*?%&#: But ain't that Bananach still comin' after us?

Lamplighter: No, no, no, they ran it off this street a long time ago.

Lamplighter: I can't say I've seen it myself, but everyone knows it hunts down any children that've lost their names. A truly wicked thing.

!+*?%&#: Oh yeah! My name!

!+*?%&#: Why? How does a fairy go about nicking someone's name? I mean, how's that even work? And if I ain't got any name, what's that make me, then?

Lamplighter: Umm. Can't say I know, to be honest.

Suddenly, a spark of inspiration lights up in Lamplighter's eyes.

Lamplighter: But I know just who would!

Lamplighter: Remember? The lady I said I'd introduce you to.

Lamplighter: She's the Administrator of the Cross Street Library—the most respected, fair, and knowledgeable person on this street. She knows everything!

Lamplighter: She'll definitely know what to do! Follow me!

Lamplighter: Although, what should I call you in the meantime, eh?

!+*?%&#: Yes, I suppose it won't do goin' round without a name, will it?

!+*?%&#: Maybe a nickname'll do for the time being.

!+*?%&#: That way, people won't have to keep shoutin', "Oi! The girl wot lost 'er name!" whenever they see me.

Lamplighter: Haha! Brilliant idea! Let's see ... How does Flutterpage sound to you?

!+*?%&#: Flutterpage?

Lamplighter: That's right! I got the idea from watching your arcane skill fluttering around that page. I think it suits you perfectly. It reminds me of a sweet bird.

Lamplighter: Do you have any paper?

The paper bird is pulled out once again. Lamplighter unfolds it and neatly writes the new name at the bottom of the shopping list.

!+*?%&#: Flutterpage ... That ain't half bad!

Flutterpage: Right then, Flutterpage it is! I'll stick with that 'til I remember who I really am.

Lamplighter: Just so then, I'll call you Flutterpage.

They finally reach the foot of a grand five-story building. Lamplighter pushes open the large, creaking door.

Before them stretches a sea of books, cascading from overloaded shelves and pooling across the floor, claiming every inch of space.

Cross Street Library

Lamplighter: Hello, Ms. Administrator, where are you? I've got a friend with some questions for you.

Administrator: Aha, let's see who we have here. A muddle-headed little scatterbrain who's gone and lost her name.

High above, a voice rings out, prompting Flutterpage to peer up toward the rafters.

There on the shelves, atop a teetering pile of books, a woman sits shrouded in shadow, her face hidden from sight.

Flutterpage: 'Ello Miss, you must be the Administrator! But, there's one thing I should mention first:

Flutterpage: The reason I went and gave myself a new name is so people wouldn't call me things like what you just called me. If you really know the answer to everything, you should've known that already.

Administrator: Indeed I did know, but that doesn't change the fact that you are, in fact, a muddle-headed little scatterbrain.

Lamplighter: Come on, Administrator, don't wind her up.

Lamplighter: Since you already know everything, could you tell us what we should do next?

Administrator: First and foremost, she should find her name without delay, otherwise ...

Administrator: Well, first things first. Little scatterbrain, think carefully: What did you eat last night?

Flutterpage: Why? What's that got to do with anythin'? Well, I had ... I had ...

Flutterpage: Hmm? Strange. I can't rightly remember.

Administrator: I see, exactly as I thought. Without a name, you'll start to forget your past; then soon enough, you'll lose your identity altogether.

Administrator: The Bananach won't let a tasty little morsel like you slip away. So it looks like you're stuck on this street, unless you intend on becoming its next meal, that is.

For a moment, Flutterpage is left speechless. Deep down, a sliver of doubt remains. Could all of this simply be a dream?

Still, the fact she can't remember her own name or what she ate is undeniable. Whether dream or reality, she must face this head-on.

Flutterpage: Alright. So, what am I supposed to do now?

Administrator: Do you know where most people end up finding what they've lost?

Flutterpage: I suppose ... In their pockets usually, wouldn't you say?

Administrator: Aha. Not such a scatterbrain after all.

Flutterpage's eyes widen as she reaches into her pocket, and sure enough, her fingers brush against something solid.

Flutterpage: Oh, this thing's been sittin' in me pocket all along.

Flutterpage: But this can't be me name, can it? I've searched it before. It's empty ...

Before Flutterpage can finish, the pouch in her hand suddenly begins to move.

Flutterpage: What's this?

Sprightly luminous dots emerge from the seemingly empty pouch and drift into the air. They orbit Flutterpage, dancing around her with a serene glow.

Lamplighter: Fireflies?

Flutterpage: No, that's not it. These are ...

Upon seeing the gentle light of these tiny entities, a strange yet familiar sensation fills Flutterpage's heart.

Flutterpage: I remember now. Last night, I had baked beans and vegetable soup!

Flutterpage: Wow! So then, these little lights must be my name!

The little, glowing entities seem to understand Flutterpage's outburst, and flit around her in two lively loops before slipping back into the "Don't! Open Me!" pouch.

Administrator: Once they've swiped a name, fairies always make a point of finding somewhere to hide it.

Administrator: Typically, they'll hide names in items others hold dear, making it all the more difficult for you to get it all back.

Administrator: But then leaving one part hidden on your person, while you remain oblivious, running around in circles ... is exactly the sort of mischief they love most.

Flutterpage: Gotta admit, it's a clever trick. Pity I'm the poor sod they've gone and played it on.

Flutterpage: Hang on a tick, when you said "leaving one part hidden on your person," did you mean there's more to my name than just these little fellas?

Administrator: Naturally. Now, I see that your name consists of seven letters, which means six are still missing.

Administrator: Mind you, these fragile little fragments won't last long once parted from their owner. You'd best retrieve them before dawn, otherwise ...

Administrator: Your name will be gone for good, and with it, so too will your identity.

Flutterpage: I've got it.

Flutterpage: I think my going home for a good telling-off's gonna have to wait.

# New Friends, Old Friends

CH23601-04

Zombie Graveyard

Flutterpage: Wow! So this is what a graveyard looks like at night. It's got that proper graveyard-y feel down pat, that's for sure!

Lamplighter: You scared?

Flutterpage: No, mate!

Flutterpage: Is that true then ... there would be, y'know, zombies about?

Lamplighter: Of course, they're right under your feet! Keep it down, though. They'll all be resting at this time of year.

Flutterpage: Oh, sorry 'bout that. Shhh.

Together, the children navigate the silent field of gravestones, venturing deeper into the graveyard.

Flutterpage: Strange, I haven't spotted any of those lights, but they should be close by, right?

Lamplighter: Didn't the Administrator say fairies like to hide names inside things people hold dear?

Lamplighter: Erm, to tell the truth, I'm not entirely sure what that means, but surely there's someone around here who might know.

Lamplighter: Speak of the devil! There's someone right over there!

Tomb Watcher: *sigh*

Resting against a gravestone, a large, eerie silhouette heaves a sorrowful sigh.

Flutterpage: 'Scuse me, mister ... but ... Oh, he don't look like the chummiest of chaps now, does he?

Flutterpage: He ain't a zombie that's woken up too early, is he?

Lamplighter: No, that's the Tomb Watcher. He isn't a zombie, just a bit odd.

Lamplighter: Though he's supposed to be already making his rounds at this time of night. What's keeping him?

Flutterpage: But maybe he knows something about me name. No harm in asking, I s'pose.

Flutterpage takes a deep breath, steadying her nerves as she prepares to approach the towering figure.

Flutterpage: 'Scuse me, sir, could I—

Tomb Watcher: S-S-S-Sorry, guv! I'll be off in a tick. Oh!

Flutterpage gawks at the tomb watcher as he topples down from the gravestone, seeming more frightened than she is at their meeting.

Tomb Watcher: Wait, who are you?

Flutterpage: Sorry if I gave you a fright. We're looking for somethin' and was wonderin' if you might be able to lend a hand?

Flutterpage: This thing I'm lookin' for, it looks a bit like a firefly, but it's actually, uh, my name.

As the words leave her mouth, Flutterpage realizes just how absurd this all sounds.

As expected, the hulking figure pulls himself upright, glaring at Flutterpage with suspicion as his menacing face edges closer.

Tomb Watcher: Harken, little one! I don't know what this is all about, but if someone put you up to takin' the mickey outta me ...

Tomb Watcher: I'll ...

Flutterpage: Ahhh. Y-You'll what?

Tomb Watcher: I'll ... I'll ...

Tomb Watcher: If you say so, I'll nothin' ... I'm just a big ol' nobody, ain't I?

Flutterpage: Uhm.

The tomb watcher slumps back against the gravestone with a long sigh, utterly defeated.

Flutterpage: Why would ya say somethin' like that?

Tomb Watcher: Word is the Bananach's back, so we set up a patrol. Everyone else's out making their rounds as we speak.

Tomb Watcher: But I can't help thinkin', what if I actually come face-to-face with the Bananach?

Tomb Watcher: I was shakin' in me boots, just thinkin' about it! That's why I ... I snuck out of my part of the graveyard.

Tomb Watcher: I know I can't keep hidin', can I? I've gotta get back, yeah, back to me post!

The tomb watcher wobbles to his feet, every step a battle against his trembling knees.

Flutterpage: No. I don't get it. You're heading off back there? Didn't you just say you were scared?

Tomb Watcher: I am scared! But, but that don't mean I can just scarper. I gotta face it. I ain't no coward!

Flutterpage: Hmm?

Flutterpage: Why not? Why can't you just leave?

Tomb Watcher: What do ya mean?

Flutterpage's tone is genuinely confused, prompting the tomb watcher and Lamplighter to exchange surprised glances.

Flutterpage: I'm thinking ... If you're that scared, why don't you get someone to cover for you?

Flutterpage: But I dunno what else you lot get up to 'round here. I reckon there must be plenty to do besides wanderin' about.

Flutterpage: What about sortin' out meals for everyone, fixin' their clothes, or even wakin' them up in the mornin'? That way, you'd still be pullin' your weight, wouldn't ya?

Tomb Watcher: I ... I can't do that! That's the kinda thing only a coward would do! They'd be out there patrollin', while I'd be stuck doing some fiddly little busywork? That ... well, that ...

Flutterpage: What's it matter, though?

Tomb Watcher: That'd make me look strange! My friends will make fun of me.

Flutterpage: ...

Flutterpage: I don't think so, no.

Flutterpage: I think ... they really ain't much good as friends at all. Real mates wouldn't treat ya like that.

Tomb Watcher: ...

The tomb watcher falls into silence for a while, emitting a mixture of confusion and helplessness from behind his mask.

Until at last, his shoulders slump gently.

Tomb Watcher: Maybe ... Maybe you're right.

Tomb Watcher: I shouldn't care what those lot think of me, should I?

He lingers there, unmoving, head drooped on the spot, and then, with unexpected resolve, takes a deep breath.

Tomb Watcher: Dash it all! I ain't goin'! Coward or not, who cares?

Tomb Watcher: Ta for that, love! Haha! I don't think I've ever felt this good in me life!

Tomb Watcher: Now, I don't 'ave a clue about this thingamajig you're lookin' for, but ...

Tomb Watcher: You're welcome to 'ave this, if you want it.

Flutterpage: A present? Oh, that's brilliant—Hold on, you made this yourself, didn't ya?

She eyes the necklace made with feathers and pebbles, tied with a common bowknot.

Tomb Watcher: Yeah, I did. Truth is, I've always been fond of makin' stuff like this, but everyone reckons it's for softies.

Flutterpage: Don't be daft! It's well impressive, it is!

Flutterpage takes the necklace and holds it against her neck, tilting her head as she visualizes wearing it.

Flutterpage: Watcha think? Reckon it suits me?

Tomb Watcher: Smashin'! Proper smashing love! Cheers for everythin', and I mean it.

Flutterpage: Why? What're you thankin' me for? You're the one who gave me a gift. It's me who should be thankin' you.

Flutterpage: Thank you!

With a small smile that sneaks through from behind his monstrous mask, the tomb watcher departs with a wave as he vanishes into the shadows.

Lamplighter: You know, I reckon not many people would've thought like you just did.

Flutterpage: What're you gettin' at?

Lamplighter: Most people would try to push him into being brave, don't you think?

Flutterpage: Why? Why should he have to be brave if that ain't what he wants to be?

Lamplighter: Because ... well, never mind.

Lamplighter: You know, I've got to say I've taken a liking to you.

Flutterpage: Thank you. Cheers, mate!

Flutterpage: But it feels like I'm forgettin' somethin' important.

Lamplighter: That's right, you certainly have.

Flutterpage: Oh yeah, my name! That's why we came here!

Flutterpage: But where could it be? Eh?

The tomb watcher's necklace begins to warm in her hand, and the fireflies fly out to dance around Flutterpage once more.

Flutterpage: This is ...

Lamplighter: Another bit of your name! Did they come out from that necklace?

Lamplighter: Of course! Ms. Administrator did warn us that fairies liked hiding names in things people cherish. Looks like she was right once again!

Flutterpage: Wow! Doesn't matter if it ain't my first time seeing this, it's still bleeding amazin'.

Flutterpage: Good news, anyway! I've snagged me my second letter, haven't I?

Flutterpage: So, it leaves us with five more to find. Urgh.

Flutterpage: Why'd there have to be so many letters in my name? If it was somethin' simple like "Me," we'd be done an' dusted by now!

Lamplighter: Haha! Now that's a thought! Still, I've got a feeling we'd somehow find ourselves in a twist anyway.

Lamplighter: Let's pick up the pace. Remember, we've only got until dawn to put your name back together.

# Flowers and Pebbles

CH23601-05

Afternoon Tea Club

Gluttonous Critters: Dearest club members! Let's see now. What do we get on our spread? What's here? What's here?

Gluttonous Critter I: Smoked salmon!

Gluttonous Critter II: Scones with blueberry jam!

Gluttonous Critter III: Chocolate and hazelnut cupcakes!

Gluttonous Critters: Fantastic! Afternoon tea time! Afternoon tea time!

Gluttonous Critters: What else is there to nibble on?

Gluttonous Critter I: Deviled eggs!

Gluttonous Critter IV: Pea soup!

Gluttonous Critter III: Pistachio macarons!

Gluttonous Critters: Fantastic! Afternoon tea time! Wait ... What?!

Gluttonous Critters: Nobody likes pea soup here. Get it gone! Get it out! Get it out!

Gluttonous Critter IV: Ugh?! Yucky, yucky, yuck!

Flutterpage and Lamplighter stare in disbelief as the unfortunate critter with the pea soup is seized and thrown out by the rest.

Flutterpage: Hey, what a waste! Pea soup ain't my favorite neither, but you shouldn't be chuckin' out good food like that!

Lamplighter: Those little things? They've always been like this. Don't let their size fool you. They're the wealthiest critters on all of Cross Street.

Gluttonous Critters: Only the most scrumptious delights deserve a spot at our table! Sit down! Sit down!

Gluttonous Critters: All friends of the Administrator are more than welcome to share in our feast! Share in our feast!

Flutterpage: Thank you, but we'll have to give it a miss this time. We're actually looking for somethin'. It's ...

The gluttonous critters exchange looks of confusion and panic, cutting Flutterpage off before she can finish.

Gluttonous Critters: What are you talking about? Something valuable? Don't look at us. We've got nothing like that here—nothing like that!

Flutterpage: No, no, no. It's not valuable on its own, but it might be inside somethin' you hold dear.

Flutterpage: Reckon you might've seen it?

The critters huddle together, murmuring amongst themselves.

Gluttonous Critters: You're after our dearest possession, aren't you? Aren't you?!

Flutterpage: No, no! I'm just askin' if you'd take a peek for me. Maybe what I'm after's hidden somewhere inside your dearest possession.

Gluttonous Critters: Our dearest possession? Okay! We'll give it to you! Give it to you!

Flutterpage: Huh?

For a second, Flutterpage is stunned, but soon her expression softens into a bright smile.

Flutterpage: Is that true then? That's so nice of you!

Gluttonous Critters: But you'll have to pay for it! In cash! In cash!

Flutterpage: Oh ...

Flutterpage: Cash.

Flutterpage is stunned by the absurdity of it all. The huddle of plump critters stare out at her expectantly.

Flutterpage: Alright, I s'pose it's only fair. Can't just go 'round asking favors for free.

Flutterpage: How much were you expecting?

Gluttonous Critters: Much obliged! Return any time! Come back soon! Come back soon!

Flutterpage: ...

Lamplighter: ...

Lamplighter: You know, I reckon you could've bargained with those little critters.

Flutterpage: Well, it's a bit late to say that now, ain't it? Why didn't you say somethin' earlier?

Lamplighter: I do apologize. I'm not very good at bargaining myself.

Flutterpage: Don't worry about it. I'm the one who messed up.

Flutterpage: You've stuck by me through all this without askin' for so much as a penny. That's more than just being a good mate. Thank you, Lamplighter. You're a true pal.

Lamplighter: Don't be silly! I'd never ask you for money!

With a weary sigh, Flutterpage inspects the critters' so-called "dearest possession," which cost her so much money.

Flutterpage: Anyways ...

Flutterpage: You reckon this really is their most dearest possession?

Lamplighter: Erm, I can't rightly say.

Flutterpage: Sarah's gonna kill me if she ever finds out I blew all our dosh on a bloomin' stone.

Flutterpage: ...

Flutterpage: Hm?

Flutterpage: Who's Sarah?

Flutterpage: Oh!

Flutterpage: That's right! She's my sister. I remember now.

The dim light of the fireflies flickers around them as Flutterpage struggles to piece together the true meaning of that name.

Yet just as quickly, her thoughts are consumed again by a chaotic void.

Lamplighter: Flutterpage, you ...

Flutterpage: I know.

Flutterpage: That ain't a good sign, is it?

# Peppy Paws

CH23601-06

Meat Canning Factory

Packleader Girt: Well, well, look who we 'ave here. A tiny squirt bold enough to come sniffing around for my finest treasure.

Flutterpage: Uh, sorry, but it's just—

Packleader Girt: You will address me as "Packleader"!

Pack Hound I: Right, Packleader!

Pack Hound II: Yes, Packleader! We weren't trying to sneak a bite outta the cans, honest!

Packleader Girt: I'm not talking to you two mutts! Go gnaw a bone somewhere else!

Pack Hound II: Yes, Packleader! Right, Packleader.

Flutterpage and Lamplighter watch in silence as the two dogs scamper off with their tails between their legs.

Flutterpage: Yes, Packleader. The truth is, I just need to borrow your treasure for a minute.

Flutterpage: You see some sneaky little fairies nicked my name, and they've got a knack for hiding the things they steal in what other people treasure most. So, I'm just checkin' if it's here.

Packleader Girt: And why do you think they enjoy hiding their spoils in such objects?

Flutterpage: I s'pose it's 'cause if it's worth somethin', they'll keep it tucked away, safe and sound, won't they?

Packleader Girt: Exactly.

Packleader Girt: Whatever troubles you've got with those little mischief-makers is none of my business. You can borrow my treasure, but it'll cost you.

Packleader Girt: Prove yourself to me in a one-on-one challenge! If you succeed, my finest treasure will be yours ... to borrow.

Lamplighter: Flutterpage ...

Lamplighter casts a worried glance at Flutterpage. A one-on-one competition against such a powerful, hulking hound hardly seems like the best course of action.

After a brief moment of thought, Flutterpage nods her head with determination.

Flutterpage: I know, Lamplighter, but it's better than coughin' up more cash. I'm game.

Flutterpage: But one thing—I get to choose the competition. Sound good to you?

Packleader Girt: Ready or not, here I come!

At the sound of Girt's voice echoing through the factory, Flutterpage, curled up in a hidden nook, presses a hand to her mouth to hide her laughter.

Flutterpage: Heh. No way she's ever gonna find me here.

Flutterpage: I'm the hide-and-seek champ. One time, no one found me till it was already pitch dark and everyone just bogged off home.

Flutterpage: Cor, look at all these tins! Jellied eels, Sunday roast, toad-in-the-hole, steak and kidney pie ...

Flutterpage: Wow! Shepherd's pie! That's my favorite! I wonder if it tastes as good in a tin as the real thing?

Pack Hound I: You aren't the only one! Every one of us pups is dying to know what it tastes like!

Flutterpage: Where'd you lot come from?!

Pack Hound I: Shh! Keep it down, or you'll get us caught.

Pack Hound II: You think you're safe here? Hah! We can smell you a mile away!

Pack Hound I: Our leader's nose is the best there is. Her sniffer's tracked down more troublemakers than we can count!

Flutterpage: Oh. You're right. You lot are dogs! I can't stick around here, so where should I go?

After exchanging a glance, the little dogs wag their tails.

Pack Hound I: If you can do us a little favor ...

Pack Hound II: We might be able to help you!

Packleader Girt: The reek of an old collar, worthless. A bottle? Not there either. Eh? What do we have here?

Packleader Girt: Tattered clothes, ink and scraps of paper, the wind's breath, and a hint of bird ... Aha!

Packleader Girt: You lose, runt. I've found you!

Girt hurls the obstacle before her aside, only to reveal an empty corner.

All that remains is a lone pair of familiar shoes and socks.

Packleader Girt: Huh?

Pack Hound I & II: Now!

Flutterpage: Attack!

Packleader Girt: Huh?!

Boom! Flutterpage kicks up a cloud of dust as she crashes down from above, executing a perfect ambush.

Flutterpage rises over Girt, who is still sprawled out and dazed beneath her, triumphantly dusting off her skirt.

Flutterpage: That's the funny thing about searching—no one ever remembers to look up, not even dogs.

Lamplighter: I can't believe it. You actually beat Girt!

Pack Hound II: Nice one! We finally got one over on our leader!

Pack Hound I: Yeah, we really did! Flutterpage, you'd better keep your promise!

The pups bound and bark with joy around Flutterpage, while their leader snarls, springing to her feet in fury.

Packleader Girt: Y-You little runts! What do you think you're doing?!

Packleader Girt: Aha! I see now. You two must've teamed up with this little squirt to sneak a bite from our tins.

Pack Hound I: You've got it wrong, Packleader! You always treat us like we're still wet behind the ears!

Pack Hound II: We ain't gonna steal tins no more, Packleader! We're good for something! Look, we even caught you off guard!

Flutterpage: Yes, Packleader Girt. They weren't helping me just so they could nick a can of food. All they wanted in return was ...

Flutterpage: ... for me to be their witness, while they proved to you that they're right clever little puppies!

Pack Hound I: That's right. We're clever little puppies! We won't steal a bite from any of the cans, and we can still lend you a paw, Packleader!

Pack Hound II: So how about taking us along on the next hunt? We hate being left behind waiting for everyone to get back.

Packleader Girt: You clueless little mutts! Don't you realize that all I do is for your own good?!

Packleader Girt: Tsk ...

Packleader Girt: So be it. I've lost, fair and square.

Packleader Girt: Bring out the treasure.

The calmer of the two puppies wags its tail, carrying over a sturdy-looking fang.

Packleader Girt: This is the fang I lost in a scrap with that Black Dog of Newgate a few years back.

Packleader Girt: It was my sharpest fang, but I won the day.

Packleader Girt: My fangs and claws are what made me the boss here. I've always counted on them to help me whenever there's a problem.

Packleader Girt: This fang is a proud reminder of that.

Packleader Girt: But, maybe it's made me a bit too proud.

Packleader Girt: Maybe I can do an even better job of being the boss around here without it. So, take it.

Flutterpage: You sure? This thing seems proper special to ya.

Packleader Girt: You think I'm the type to second-guess myself? Let's not drag this out.

Flutterpage: Alright, no point arguing, I s'pose. It looks proper fierce, after all! This could be exactly what I need.

As Flutterpage expects, once she accepts the fang, those familiar glimmers surround her again.

Flutterpage: Wow! The fifth letter! It's here!

Lamplighter: Just two more to go.

Lamplighter: We're making decent progress. You even charmed your way past Packleader Girt.

Flutterpage: Let's see where them glow bugs are pointing to next. Eh?

Lamplighter: Funny, they're still heading east. But there's nothing else east on Cross Street, right?

As their eyes meet, they come to realize what this means.

Flutterpage: I'm thinking ... That means the rest of my name's not on Cross Street, don't it?

Lamplighter bright face darkens into a frown.

Lamplighter: It's out there, where the Bananach dwells.

# Through the Darkness

CH23601-07

# Solution

CH23601-08

Flutterpage: You know what? I've been thinkin' 'bout all this, tryin' to make sense of it all.

Flutterpage: Grown-ups are always comin' up with fairy tales to make us kids toe the line. Not me, though.

Flutterpage: Witches by the pond, demons under the bed ... Once you've had a thought through all the "whys," it ain't hard to see they're just grown-up fibs.

Flutterpage: But this time, things are a tad trickier than usual.

Flutterpage: A world full of wonders, a best mate I could only dream of, a bunch of cheeky fairies, a terrifyin' monster, some magical trinkets. Overall, one heart-poundin' adventure ...

Flutterpage: All those fairy tale things appeared out of nowhere, right before me eyes, like an adventure book made special for me.

Flutterpage: If this were a riddle, what'd the answer be? That's what I was thinking about.

Lamplighter: ...

Lamplighter: So, do you know?

Flutterpage: Yes. You gave me a clue, didn't ya?

Lamplighter: Of course, we are! Critters have called this place home since before anyone can remember.

Lamplighter: Only thing is, it looks different to each person who enters it. Most folks can't manage to find their way into "this" Cross Street.

Lamplighter: And it's even harder if there's no one to guide you.

Flutterpage: Right from the start, I had a feeling the critters were a bit familiar.

Flutterpage: That tomb watcher fella, the lady and her flowers, them cheeky critters at the club, and that Packleader Girt ...

Flutterpage: That tomb watcher might seem big and tough, but he's softer than he looks. To him, being well-thought of by the others is what mattered most.

Flutterpage: He's just like my dad.

Flutterpage: What I said to the tomb watcher, it's really what I've been wanting to say to me dad. I've always wished he wouldn't care so much about what other people think.

Lamplighter: ...

Lamplighter is silent, watching Flutterpage as though encouraging her to continue.

Flutterpage: The lady in the garden, she's a bit like me mum. Though, let's be clear, my mum ain't near half as frightenin'!

Flutterpage: But she fusses over her weavin' just the same as that lady in the garden did her flowers.

Flutterpage: Mum's always knitting and weaving every day just to make ends meet, and all the while I ain't seen her smile over one thing she made, not even those cute little scarves.

Flutterpage: I always keep me distance, worried that she might bite my head off or somethin', but I know she's working herself to the bone for us and I just wish she could find a bit happiness in her work again. I guess what I oughta tell her is that those scarves of hers are beautiful.

Flutterpage: As for Girt, I know exactly who she is—my sister, Sarah.

Flutterpage: She's so bloomin' proud of herself, and everything's gotta go her way. And like Girt did with those pups, she always treats me like I'm just a kid. Sometimes that really ticks me off.

Flutterpage: If there's a chance, I s'pose I'll try to surprise Sarah and make her proud of me, just like how them puppies did with their boss.

Flutterpage gives a cheeky grin and makes a silly face at Lamplighter.

She achieves the desired effect, and Lamplighter laughs gently.

Lamplighter: How about the others?

Flutterpage: The rest? Well, them critters at the club are a bit like my schoolmates.

Flutterpage: Every day's the same with them, jabberin' about the same old rubbish. They all look and sound alike to me like they was just repeating each other. Drive me barmy, they do.

Flutterpage: But maybe I was wrong about 'em—like I was those critters. For all their chattering, that little stone really was their "dearest possession." Otherwise, the fireflies wouldn't have hidden there.

Flutterpage: And that library lady, the one who reckons she knows it all.

Flutterpage: Maybe she does got all the answers, but I ain't gonna go askin' her every little thing. And who's to say she ain't just feeding me a load 'o cobblers? I'd have no way of tellin'.

Flutterpage: I gotta figure these sorts of answers for myself. So ...

Flutterpage: I s'pose the Administrator's a bit like me, ain't she? I shouldn't be relying on people for everything. It's my job to find me own answers.

Lamplighter: Now that's a very interesting thought. So then who's left?

Flutterpage: The Bananach. Though I still ain't sure what it was, to be honest. But I've got a strange feeling about it.

Flutterpage: What a creepy thing—going after kids without names. It whispered all sorts of rubbish to me, like "give up," tryin' to make me "stay here forever" ...

Flutterpage: I guess that's got something to do with you, don't it?

Eyes slightly wide open, Lamplighter seems to have heard an unexpected answer. Flutterpage is also confused by her reaction.

Flutterpage: Oh? You telling me that ain't so?

Lamplighter: I'm just curious. Why you'd think it'd have anything to do with me?

Flutterpage: I suppose ... because you said this thing was horrible, but it turned out ... Hmm, I guess I'm wrong. It isn't you, not exactly.

Flutterpage: Maybe it's those fears in your mind that you only think are scary. Uh, I'm not sure how to put it, but it's all those scary and annoying things we gotta face sometimes.

Flutterpage waves her arms in the air, hoping to find the right word for the strange entity, but nothing ever quite fits.

Lamplighter: Then you're saying I'm the one behind all this? I'm the big baddie?

Flutterpage: I didn't say nothin' like that.

Flutterpage: Because everything, everything here ...

Flutterpage flings her arms open, like she's drawing a line from one edge of the world to the other.

Flutterpage: None of it's real.

Flutterpage: C'mon, of course it's all made-up nonsense. Fun nonsense, but still. I'm eleven years old, ya know!

Lamplighter: So, then what is all this?

Flutterpage: That's the question I've been turnin' over in me head all this time.

Flutterpage: I'm thinking, when did all this start?

Flutterpage: It weren't on that strange Cross Street, and it weren't in the woods where the Bananach started chasin' us. It was right here.

Flutterpage: I suppose, maybe it's 'cause I opened this bag here. That's when all this started.

Lamplighter: You're saying it all started with that little pouch?

Flutterpage: That's what I reckoned at first, until I remembered that story about the lake.

Flutterpage: Sure are! 'Bout witches dragging people into the water, and fairies thieving stuff ... There are loads of them.

Flutterpage: But I remembered somethin'. Dad told me one of the saddest stories of 'em all.

Flutterpage: The tale says, years ago, there was a little girl—just about my age, and ... well, she went through a lot of horrible things.

Flutterpage: She was sad and disappointed, so off she goes to the lake, leavin' all the things what made her miserable behind for good.

Flutterpage: That's why the grown-ups don't want other kids coming 'round here.

Lamplighter: ...

Flutterpage: 'Cause that little girl was you, wasn't it?

Lamplighter: ...

Flutterpage: So, it didn't begin with the bag. It was me laying here, makin' that wish.

Flutterpage: I was down in the dumps back then, and made a wish to fly off to someplace different.

Liberti: I want to be like you, then I could fly, fly off somewhere else.

Liberti: Might be somewhere else. There's an exciting adventure waitin' for me, far away from all these worries.

Liberti: Could you take me there?

Flutterpage: You're here all because I made a wish.

Flutterpage: It was you that swiped my name, all so I'd forget the past and stay here with you, in this "somewhere else."

Flutterpage: Lamplighter. The last letter of my name ... you've got it in your hand, ain't you?

Lamplighter: ...

Lamplighter: That I do.

Lamplighter unclenches her hand, and the last lost flitter of light escapes.

Lamplighter: This is the last letter of your name. Take it, and you won't forget anything about yourself. You can go back to where you came from.

Lamplighter: But, is that what you really want?

Lamplighter: Your world isn't like this one. It doesn't hold the same kind of beauty. You've seen that by now, haven't you?

Lamplighter: There's a limit to what your winds can clear. You won't find an answer to every question.

Lamplighter: Flutterpage, my friend, I really like you. Stay with me, won't you?

Lamplighter: You'd never have a dull moment, I swear it. We'd be happy every day. Doesn't that sound wonderful?

Flutterpage: No.

Flutterpage: Sorry. Thanks for the invite, and for answerin' me wish, but, I s'pose I don't truly wanna leave my home behind.

Lamplighter: Because of your family?

Flutterpage: Yes, they may drive me up the wall, but I still love 'em, don't I?

Flutterpage: But it's not just 'cause of them.

Flutterpage: When we met, remember me saying I couldn't wrap my head 'round Sarah's "There's no why"? I said, grown-ups musta known sometimes there weren't no why.

Flutterpage: But that's a load of rubbish. Truth is, I know the answer, only I've been hiding from it.

Lamplighter: So, what do you think the answer is?

Flutterpage: That is: there's no why without a reason why.

Lamplighter: ...

Lamplighter: Heh ...

Lamplighter: Hahaha! Your answer is even more of a tongue twister than the question!

Lamplighter smiles, not in the same dark way as before; it makes Flutterpage want to smile along with her.

And so Flutterpage chuckles along.

Flutterpage: Hehe, I know, I was thinkin' the same thing.

Flutterpage: But that's my answer, and I'm stickin' to it. I'm sure of that.

Flutterpage: I ain't saying Sarah and the others are lying. "There's no why" might well be her answer, but that don't mean it's gotta be mine.

Flutterpage: Nothing will stop me finding the answer myself. I'll keep thinking and asking questions, even if no one can answer me.

Lamplighter: That is a wonderful answer.

Lamplighter: You've really surprised me, Flutterpage.

With a soft chuckle, Lamplighter finally lets the firefly stumble its way over to Flutterpage.

It settles on Flutterpage's shoulder and blends into the moonlight, lighting up the lingering darkness in the girl's heart.

Lamplighter: My friend, Liberti Grove, you did it.

Flutterpage: ...

Lamplighter: You've chosen a difficult path, one I couldn't choose for myself.

Lamplighter: And I ... I'll respect your decision, and I wish you all the best from the bottom of my heart.

Lamplighter: It's alright. This is just a parting of ways. I've grown used to it.

Flutterpage: Lamplighter, I ...

Lamplighter: Don't make that sad face, Liberti.

Lamplighter: After this, you'll forget all about me and what happened here, and then you'll meet new friends and go on new adventures.

Lamplighter: But that's only fair. You're a sweet girl, and you deserve to have many more friends.

Flutterpage: Hang on! New friends or not, you're still my best mate! I'll never forget you.

Flutterpage's frantic words fall on deaf ears as Lamplighter offers nothing but a smile. A silent, broken smile.

Lamplighter: It's time.

She raises her stick again and strikes the ground.

Though she does so gently this time, the sound of the staff striking the ground rings deafeningly in Flutterpage's ears.

The lamp in Lamplighter's hand erupts with light, casting a brilliance far surpassing anything before it.

Flutterpage: This is ... the sun, it's risin'!

Lamplighter: Yes. It's time to awaken from your dream.

Flutterpage: No! I still have more I want—

Flutterpage: ... to ... say ...

Lamplighter: Goodbye, my friend.

???: Liberti.

Liberti: zzzZZZ

???: Liberti!

Liberti: Not now ... Ollie ...

???: Oh ...

Sarah: This ain't a chicken coop, and I'm not your bleedin' rooster! Now get up, you little so-and-so!

Liberti: Whoa?!

Liberti: Sis? I'm ...

Sarah: Sent you out for a bit of shopping, and instead you stay out all night?! All 'cause you got a scolding, you decide to turn into a little runaway riff-raff?

Sarah: Have you any idea how long we've all been searching for you? You're in for it now!

Liberti: What? I didn't ... Wait. I've been gone a whole night?

Indeed, the morning light shines warmly, but for Liberti, the events of the previous night have faded into a blank haze.

Sarah: Was it the sweets? All this on account of me saying I wouldn't let you get any?

With a sharp frown, Sarah fishes out a handful of candies and slaps them into Liberti's palm.

Sarah: There you go! And here I thought I was teaching you about the value of money. We're not made of the stuff, but we're not penniless either! If you're so desperate for a bit of candy, speak up instead of pulling stunts like this.

Liberti: ...

Sarah: What? Not enough for you? Let me tell you right now, don't you dream of expecting an apology from me.

Liberti: I didn't have me hopes up or nothin'. Still, thanks, sis.

Liberti puts the candy in her pocket and discovers something else hidden within.

Liberti: Did—Did I fold this?

Liberti looks at the bird, and a faint memory surfaces. She set this bird free, letting it fly into the sky.

And at that moment, in her memory, someone else was there with her.

A sensation lingers in Liberti's heart, leaving her feeling as though she has lost something. She unfolds the paper bird in her hands.

Liberti: Potatoes, bread, three cans o' beans, cabbage, carrots, and ...

Liberti: And ...

Her eyes lock in place.

At the very bottom of the shopping list, a line of elegant handwriting stands out from the scrawl above it.

Sarah: "Flutterpage" ... What's a "Flutterpage"?

Liberti: It's ... It's ...

Bird: Chirps.

Liberti: It's you!

The familiar bird from before returns.

It lands on Liberti's shoulder, tilting its head as its shining eyes meet hers.

Like a spark cutting through the fog, a vivid memory leaps to life in Liberti's mind.

Liberti: This is a name.

Liberti: My other name.

Though her recollections are still hazy, an inexplicable feeling reveals the answer to her.

It is a gift, sent to her from her mysterious friend, wrapped in the most beautiful of blessings.

Bird: Chirps.

The little bird flutters its wings and alights from her shoulder.

It glides up over the eaves and soars above the streets of London, riding the wind into the distant horizon.